

What Should We Strive For in Our Life?

A Short Play in One Act

Characters

Chen Wei - A software engineer at a top tech company, recently promoted

Li Mei - A rural school teacher in a mountain village in Yunnan

Zhao Yang - A freelance photographer who travels across China

Xiao He - A medical worker in an ICU ward, just finished a night shift

Setting: A cozy coffee shop on a Saturday afternoon. Four old college friends meet for their annual reunion. Soft music plays in the background.

Scene 1: The Reunion

(The four friends sit around a small round table, coffee cups in hand. They have just finished exchanging pleasantries.)

CHEN WEI

(checking his phone) Sorry, sorry — I had to answer an email from our CEO. You know how it is at a big tech company. But hey, it's good to see all of you!

ZHAO YANG

(laughing) Look at you, Mr. Director! Two years ago we graduated, and now you're already a senior engineer. I saw your new car in the parking lot — not bad!

CHEN WEI

(smiling proudly) Well, you know, hard work pays off. When I chose computer science, my parents were so happy. They said I'd make good money. And look — I just bought an apartment in the city center. What about you guys? What have you been striving for?

XIAO HE

(sipping her coffee slowly, looking tired but calm) I've been striving to keep people alive. I work in the ICU at the provincial hospital. Last night, I saved a patient who had been in cardiac arrest for seven minutes. Seven minutes. That experience... it changes how you see life.

ZHAO YANG

(eyes wide) Wow, Xiao He, that's intense. I can't imagine that kind of pressure.

XIAO HE

It is pressure. My salary is nothing compared to Chen Wei's. I work night shifts, I miss holidays with my family, and sometimes I cry in the bathroom after losing a patient. But you know what? When a patient's family holds my hand and says thank you with tears in their eyes — that's worth more than any bonus.

Scene 2: The Teacher's Choice

LI MEI

(quietly) I think I understand what you mean, Xiao He.

CHEN WEI

Li Mei, you've been quiet. Tell us — how's the teaching going?

LI MEI

(smiling) It's going well. Actually, better than I expected. Let me tell you something. When I graduated, I got two offers: one from a top private school in Shanghai with triple the salary, and one from a village school in Yunnan. Everyone told me to take the Shanghai job.

ZHAO YANG

But you chose Yunnan?

LI MEI

I did. My parents were furious. My boyfriend at the time broke up with me because he said I was throwing my life away. But I went anyway. And let me tell you why.

CHEN WEI

Please do. Because from the outside, it does look like a strange choice.

LI MEI

In my village school, most of the kids' parents work in cities far away. The kids live with their grandparents. Many of them have never seen the ocean, never used a computer, never even dreamed of going to university. Last semester, one of my students — a 12-year-old girl — wrote in her essay: 'My teacher showed me that the world is bigger than these mountains. I want to go to college and become a doctor.' When I read that, I cried. That's why I'm there. Those kids need someone to believe in them. And I believe in them.

XIAO HE

(wiping her eyes) That's beautiful, Li Mei.

Scene 3: The Photographer's Dream

ZHAO YANG

You guys are making me feel like I'm the only one chasing something... ordinary.

CHEN WEI

Don't say that. You're a photographer! That sounds pretty cool.

ZHAO YANG

(laughing) Cool, maybe. But my parents think I'm unemployed. They keep asking me when I'll get a 'real job.' I travel around China, take photos of sunsets, old villages, people's faces. I sell some prints online, teach photography workshops, and barely make ends meet sometimes. But last month, I spent a week with a family of Tibetan herders in Qinghai. The grandmother, she's 82, and she smiled at me — this huge, beautiful smile — and I took her portrait. When I showed her the photo, she said she'd never seen herself looking so alive. I framed that photo. That's my treasure.

XIAO HE

So you strive for moments.

ZHAO YANG

Exactly. Moments that make people feel alive. That's worth more than a steady paycheck.

Scene 4: What We Strive For

CHEN WEI

(thoughtfully) You know, listening to you guys... I've been thinking. I work 70 hours a week. I have money, I have the apartment, but... when was the last time I felt truly alive? I can't remember. Maybe I've been striving for the wrong thing.

LI MEI

Chen Wei, don't be too hard on yourself. Your work builds things that connect millions of people. That matters. The question is — does it make YOU happy?

CHEN WEI

(pauses) Honestly? Some days yes, some days no. But hearing you all tonight... I think I need to find more of the 'yes' days. Maybe I should use my skills for something I care about — like building educational technology for rural schools like yours, Li Mei.

LI MEI

(smiling) Now THAT would be something worth striving for.

XIAO HE

(raising her cup) Let me say something. In the ICU, I see people at their most vulnerable. You know what they care about at the end? Not money. Not fame. They care about the people they love and the things they did that made a difference. That's what we should strive for — a life that matters to someone.

ZHAO YANG

(raising his cup too) To a life that matters.

LI MEI

To a life that matters.

CHEN WEI

(raising his cup, smiling) To a life that matters.

(The four friends clink their coffee cups together. The soft music continues to play. The curtain falls.)

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